



Still Groping in the Dark

LUCKNOW Even after being out of power in Uttar Pradesh for 19 long years, the Congress is still groping in the dark. At a party conference in Kanpur on March 30-31, the Congress high command exposed its dearth of fresh ideas for wooing the

masses back to its fold. One faction mooted leaning on the shoulders of former chief minister and Samajwadi Party chief Mulayam Singh Yadav to make some headway into the state's votebank. Former Madhya Pradesh chief minister and party

incharge of the state Digvijay Singh said, "Mulayam Singh Yadav has been instrumental in defeating BJP in the state in the last Lok Sabha elections." What he forgot was that Mulayam had been betraying the Congress since 1991. However, party President Sonia Gandhi said that they would go to the hustings

alone.

Also on the agenda was cannon fire aimed at Chief Minister Mayawati who has frustrated the Congress's plans in the state by emerging as a strong leader championing the Dalit cause. Sonia vented her ire at the "misuse of Central funds allocated" to Uttar Pradesh for development.

Eager to corner Mayawati, the Congress leadership announced their support to Bharatiya Kisan Union chief Mahendra Singh Tikait, who is at loggerheads with the chief minister. The proclamation of support to Tikait may lead to Dalits—who had united under the BSP—veer away from the Congress's vote bank and may ultimately dampen the party's plans of a revival in the state. Clearly, it seems that the Congress high command's poll strategy is on the wrong track in Uttar Pradesh. **by Subhash Mishra**

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

With talk of a reshuffle of the Union Cabinet gaining ground, Congress groupies feel there will only be minor tinkering with portfolios, but titans of India Inc, who know the rulers' mind better, aver that there will be large scale changes.

VOICES

"We can't tolerate naming the tulip garden (in Srinagar) after Indian leaders. These are the people who snatched our freedom."

Syed Ali Shah Geelani, Hurriyat leader

"What's happening in Bengal is not anti-liberalisation. Whatever we are doing in Bengal, we are asking Manmohan Singh to do for India."

Sitaram Yechury, CPI(M) Politburo member

"When one rupee is spent for the poor, everybody asks why we are spending it. When the same one rupee goes to the non-poor, there is no criticism."

Rahul Gandhi, Congress general secretary

"Where is Congress in Uttar Pradesh? We do not feel any need to fight them as they have been reduced to a small party there. The SP is the largest secular force in the state."

Amar Singh, Samajwadi Party general secretary

"If the IPL is not a winning business, I won't be able to survive unlike other corporates in this business. If it doesn't work for one or two years, then I'll be doing my films again."

Shah Rukh Khan, actor